

BEYOND THE TILES

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”נתן ה' לכם לב לדעת עינים לראות
ואזנים לשמוע...ואולך אתכם ארבעים שנה”

After experiencing forty years of the Aibershter's care in the midbar, Moshe points out to the Yidden that Hashem gave them a heart to recognize His true kindness, eyes to see it and ears to hear it. The Rebbe often quoted this posuk as a moshol to convey that a 40-year anniversary indicates that the person or subject has acquired an unprecedented depth and maturity and has now become exponentially more powerful.

As we mark 40 years since the Rebbe launched Mivtza Taharas HaMishpocha, may our having reached this zenith urge us to intensify our efforts and strengthen the way we observe and promote this mivtza so that we reach every person.

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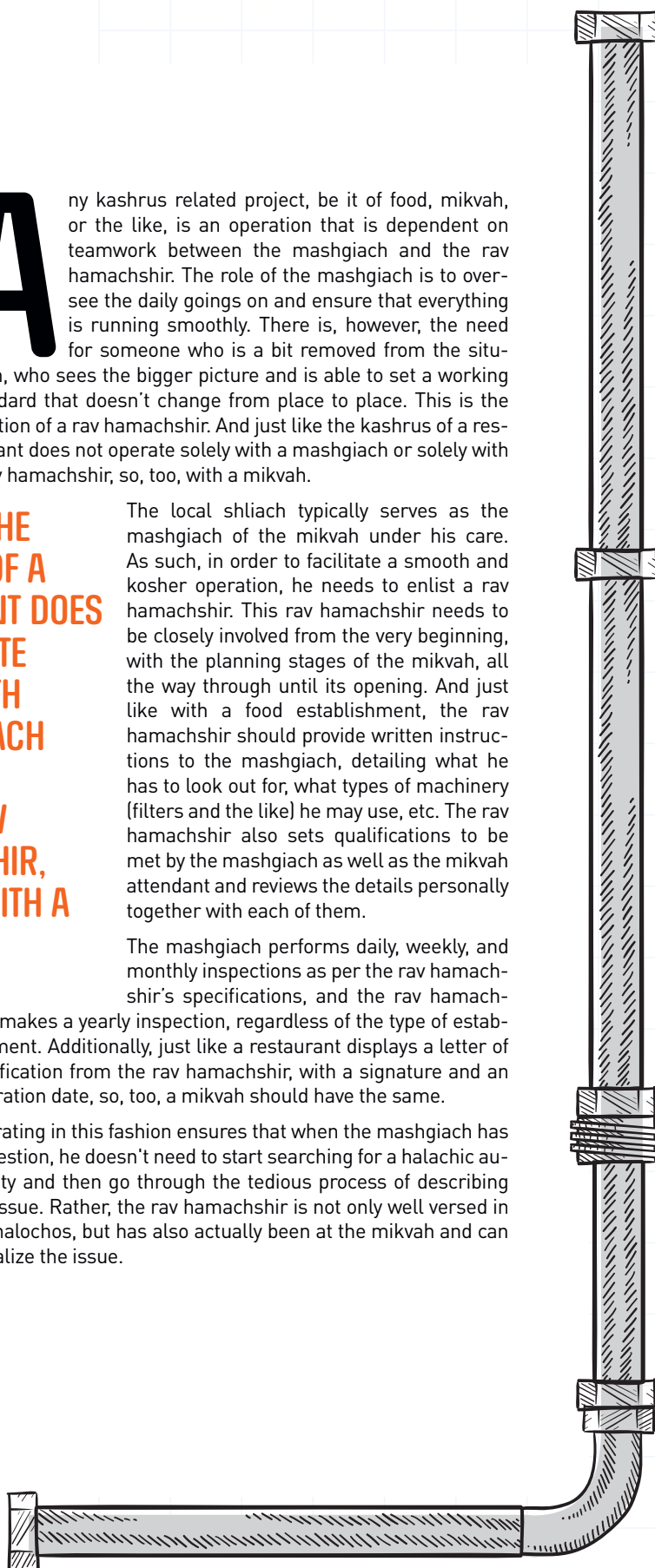
Any kashrus related project, be it of food, mikvah, or the like, is an operation that is dependent on teamwork between the mashgiach and the rav hamachshir. The role of the mashgiach is to oversee the daily goings on and ensure that everything is running smoothly. There is, however, the need for someone who is a bit removed from the situation, who sees the bigger picture and is able to set a working standard that doesn't change from place to place. This is the function of a rav hamachshir. And just like the kashrus of a restaurant does not operate solely with a mashgiach or solely with a rav hamachshir, so, too, with a mikvah.

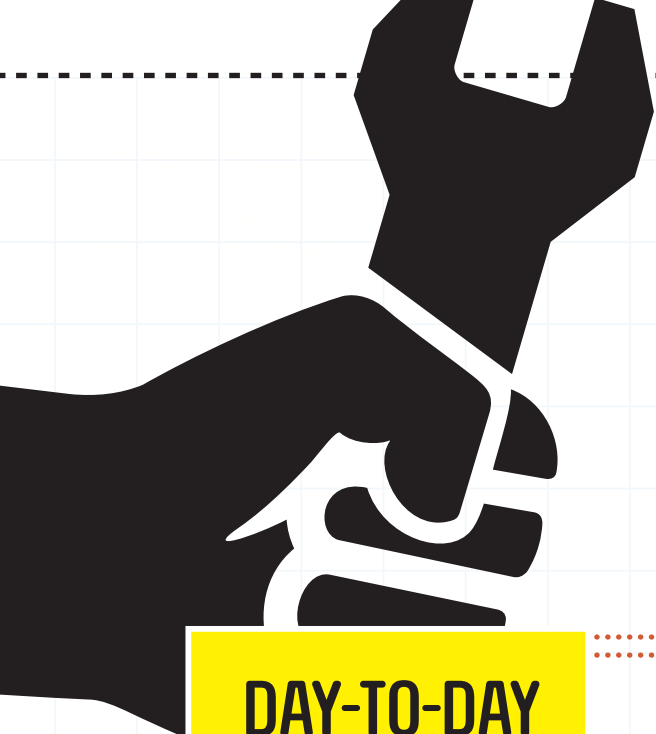
JUST LIKE THE KASHRUS OF A RESTAURANT DOES NOT OPERATE SOLELY WITH A MASHGIACH OR SOLELY WITH A RAV HAMACHSHIR, SO, TOO, WITH A MIKVAH.

The local shliach typically serves as the mashgiach of the mikvah under his care. As such, in order to facilitate a smooth and kosher operation, he needs to enlist a rav hamachshir. This rav hamachshir needs to be closely involved from the very beginning, with the planning stages of the mikvah, all the way through until its opening. And just like with a food establishment, the rav hamachshir should provide written instructions to the mashgiach, detailing what he has to look out for, what types of machinery (filters and the like) he may use, etc. The rav hamachshir also sets qualifications to be met by the mashgiach as well as the mikvah attendant and reviews the details personally together with each of them.

The mashgiach performs daily, weekly, and monthly inspections as per the rav hamachshir's specifications, and the rav hamachshir makes a yearly inspection, regardless of the type of establishment. Additionally, just like a restaurant displays a letter of certification from the rav hamachshir, with a signature and an expiration date, so, too, a mikvah should have the same.

Operating in this fashion ensures that when the mashgiach has a question, he doesn't need to start searching for a halachic authority and then go through the tedious process of describing the issue. Rather, the rav hamachshir is not only well versed in the halochos, but has also actually been at the mikvah and can visualize the issue.





FREQUENTLY ASKED SHAYLOS

DAY-TO-DAY MIKVAH OPERATIONS

1 When does a shayla need to be asked with regard to the mikvah building or בורות?

A: 1. When something has changed or will be changed: Regardless of what it is, a rov competent in hilchos mikvaos should be consulted prior to any repairs or renovations being made in any part of the mikvah building. Even something as simple as changing a wire, replacing a broken toilet, or installing an air conditioner can create a shayla.

2. With regard to maintenance and operation: If there is an ongoing operational difficulty, such as an issue with the water temperature, water level in the mikvah or humidity level in the mikvah room, advice should be sought from your rav hamachshir. Though your question may not be halachic in nature, it is very likely that it has arisen at other mikvaos and may be easily resolved.

2 How often does the mikvah need to be inspected?

A: Experience has shown that, with time, things happen and evolve without people realizing that a shayla has been created. Though the only time that a

mikvah needs to be inspected is upon experiencing a problem, such as if the mikvah is losing water (see question below), it is important for it to be inspected periodically, at least once a year.¹

3 What do I need to know about operating my mikvah's filter?

A: Many mikvaos employ the use of a filtering system. The filtering system that has been traditionally used in mikvaos for many years, the pool/spa filter, removes water from the mikvah, filters it, and then returns it to the mikvah. This filter **must** be turned off before the mikvah is used. As such, it is important to set an organized system into place to ensure that the filtering stops before nightfall. This includes setting a timer appropriately (and adjusting when the days get longer and again when the days get shorter) as well as ensuring that the filter is connected to a light in the mikvah room that indicates whether the filter is on or off. This is especially important at mikvaos that employ volunteer mashgichos who may not necessarily come to the mikvah frequently. If this filter was inadvertently

"...advice should be sought from your rav hamachshir. Though your question may not be halachic in nature, it is very likely that it has arisen at other mikvaos and may be easily resolved."

in operation during tevila, a rov must be contacted immediately.

There are two other types of filters, the May Galim and the Lakewood filter, both of which clean the water while it is in the בור הטבילה itself. L'chatchila, these filters should be shut during tevilas noshim. If they were inadvertently in operation during tevila, the tevila is kosher.

Regardless of what system you have in place, it is important to let people know that the water is indeed kept clean.

4 Following the guidance of the Rebbe Rashab of the Chabad mikvaos have the rain-water pool (בור של) beneath the pool used for immersing (בור הטבילה). What do I need to know before emptying or refilling the lower pool of its rainwater?

A: Refilling the בור with מי גשמים is a tremendous responsibility. Accordingly, it should be done in consultation with your rav hamachshir.

One example of what is involved includes ascertaining that the בור and cavities (i.e. the pump sump) are completely dry prior to refilling the בור with new rainwater. This will entail climbing into the בור, wiping it dry with towels and perhaps even using a blow-dryer to ensure that not even one drop of water remains. Additionally, it is important to ascertain

that the pipe that brings the city water to the mikvah be disconnected with a disconnection valve, rendering it impossible, even by human error, for city water to enter the בור של מי גשמים.

5 How do I ensure that water is not leaking from my mikvah?

A: At any time when you are certain that the mikvah will not be used for 24-48 hours (such as the morning before Tisha b'Av), turn off the filter and mark the water level of the mikvah with a marker or piece of tape. In addition, place a full cup of water somewhere in the mikvah room. After 24 hours, check to see whether the water level in the mikvah has dropped. If it has not dropped, or if the amount of water that is missing is parallel to the amount that is missing from the cup of water, you can be assured that there is no leak whatsoever, and that the drop in water level is due to evaporation. If, however, the water level in the mikvah is different than before and does not match that of the cup of water, a leak should be suspected and a rov should be contacted immediately. This test should be performed at any time that you suspect a leak and at least once a year.

6 It barely ever rains in my city. Is there any other way to go about collecting rainwater?

A: There are solutions to

this challenge (like using natural ice blocks or snow²) but they are highly complex and should only be done under the guidance of your rav hamachshir.

7 This afternoon, my city experienced a minor earthquake. The mikvah is scheduled to be used tonight but I am concerned that there may be a leak somewhere. What should I do?

A: As you do not have any proof that there is actually a leak, the mikvah may be used tonight but should be inspected at the next possible opportunity as described in the previous question. It should be noted that the mikvaos that have been built with reinforcing steel as per the specifications of Rabbi Zalman Shimon Dworkin a"h, are highly unlikely to be damaged by minor earthquakes.

8 May the אבן השיש (man-hole cover to the בור התחתון) be made of plastic or glass so as to facilitate easier removal?

A: If the אבן השיש is positioned in a place where a person is likely to stand, it must be made of stone. If it is positioned underneath the steps, it may be made of any material. Mats and platforms of any material other than stone are not permitted on the mikvah floor.

9 May a card with the brocha for tevila be displayed in the mikvah room?

A: A brocha card may be displayed in the mikvah room if it does not contain Hashem's name.





SAVE THE DATE!

The importance of **keeping a log** that includes dates and details of all developments at the mikvah cannot be understated. Make a habit of writing a report in a **pecially designated calendar or log book** every time you inspect the mikvah and any time any changes are made. Doing so will give you what to work with if a question arises.

Gathering snow for the mikvah in Salt Lake City, Utah (above) and S. Paul, Minnesota (below).



1. הרמ"א סי' רא ס"ד כותב "דרוב המצוין אצל מקוה ועושין כדי להכשירה, בקיפין הן ובודאי בהכשר מילא אותה", היינו שסומכים כשבנו המקוה תיקנו ועשו הכל ע"פ הלכה, ובפרט ביודעים ומכירים מי בנאו וכו'. אבל כיון שבכ"ז במושך הזמן לפעמים מתקנים ומשפצים, לכן יש לוודאות שאכן נעשו בכשרות (וראה שו"ת מנחת יצחק ח"ה סי' צג). ועיקר הבדיקה הוא לוודאות שהבורות אינם זוחלים, וכן בדיקת הגג, המרזבות והצנורות לודאות שלא חלו בהם שינויים מזמן בנייתם, ולא יגרמו לפסול שאובים.

2. כמבואר במשנה מקואות פ"ז ה"א. וראה בארוכה בספר מקוה מים ח"א עמ' קעט קונטרס "הצעת תיקון מקוה במקום שאין מי גשמים".

TEVILA

1 A few minutes before the mikvah was meant to be used, a pail of dirty water that had just been used to mop the floor spilled into the mikvah. What should be done?

A: As long as the spill did not alter the appearance of the water, the dirty water is not of halachic concern. A hand-held net should be used to remove any visible dirt so as not to cause questionable chatzitza. Care should however be taken to ensure that the cleaning solutions that were mixed into the water are not hazardous to a person's health and that the state of the water will not cause the person's mikvah experience to be a negative one. (Chlorine can be used to kill the germs and will dissipate quickly.)

2 Upon arriving to the mikvah this evening, I discovered that the בור הטבילה was completely empty. How full does the בור הטבילה need to be in order to facilitate kosher immersion?

A: Before filling the בור, it is important to verify that the reason it was emptied was for cleaning purposes and not due to an unverified shayla.

The בור הטבילה typically needs to be filled to the point that a person can stand comfortably

within it with the water reaching well above the waist, approximately 48-50 inches (1.2-1.27 meters) above the floor.³ This is to ensure that there is no need for the person to unnecessarily bend or crouch, thereby creating folds in the skin. At the same time, it is important to ensure that the water is not too deep, preventing the possibility that the person will be fearful and not completely focused at the time of tevila.

However, in the event of the circumstances described in the question above, if there is no other mikvah nearby and the mikvah in question is one of בור על גבי בור,⁴ if the mikvah is filled at least 25 inches high with water, kosher tevila can be performed. It is imperative that the mashgicha ensures that the entire body is immersed at once, without even one hair protruding from the water.⁵

3 Someone used the mikvah last night and only realized this morning that she had forgotten to remove her earrings beforehand. What should be done?

A: Clip-on earrings are considered a chatzitza and she must toivel again. Earrings that run through a hole in the ear and are not attached to the ear are

not considered a chatzitza בדיעבד. If they run through the ear but are also attached to the ear with a backing or the like, l'chatchila she should toivel again. If this presents extreme difficulty, it is possible to rely upon those who maintain that this does not constitute a chatzitza. This is only if she does not usually remove her earrings when she showers, goes to sleep, etc. If she does remove them, the earrings are considered a chatzitza according to all opinions and she must toivel again.⁶

4 Someone used the mikvah and realized afterward that she had forgotten to make a brocha. What should she do?

A: If she already left the mikvah room, she does not return to toivel again with a brocha.⁷

5 May an extremely short person stand on a slotted wooden or plastic platform in the mikvah?

A: No. Regardless of the shape or dimensions, moveable platforms are not permitted.⁸ Even permanent platforms made of materials other than stone are not permitted. (Today's mikvaos are mostly built with multi-level floors so as to accommodate people of various heights.)

Which related halochos are the most important for a shliach who has a mikvah to constantly review?

Every shliach must ensure that he is very knowledgeable in הלכות נדה והלכות חציצה, especially with regard to contemporary shaylos. Reviewing the related halochos in Shulchon Oruch as well as ספר טהרה כהלכה by Rabbi Yekusiel Farkash is a good start.



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6 I am frequently asked as to whether a person may use the mikvah while wearing permanently attached eyebrows or nails, dyed hair, a cast, dental braces, and the like. Is there a clear cut answer?

A: All of the above questions have been addressed in פרק כ of ספר טהרה כהלכה. Due to the many details involved in each circumstance, I will not answer them here. I will however encourage you to study and frequently review these halachos as there is no one clear-cut answer and these questions do frequently present themselves to shlichim.

7 In one case, immediately prior to tevila, the person in question informed the mikvah attendant that only a הפסק טהרה and bedika on the seventh day were performed. In another instance, immediately prior to tevila, the person in question informed the mikvah attendant that no הפסק טהרה or bedikos were performed, but that it is unquestionably the twelfth day of the cycle. May tevila be performed in either of these cases?

A: A rov competent in hilchos tahara

should be consulted as the answers are case-specific.

8 A divorcee requested to be able to use the mikvah solely for an invigorating spiritual experience in the face of multiple hardships she is presently experiencing. May this be done without any prior preparations?

A: Contact a rov with regard to someone who has previously been married or is presently married

but not keeping Taharas Hamishpocha. A single woman, however, is never allowed to use the mikvah until the night before her wedding.⁹

9 The nearest mikvah is a six-hour drive away. May a woman travel by car alone with a non-Jewish male driver?

A: In a case of extreme need, this is permitted (at night) only if the lights in the car are turned on so

that pedestrian passerby or those driving by can see what is going on inside. If the location is one where there are no passersby, a shomer is necessary to prevent yichud. If no shomer is available, it is permissible to rely upon those who allow this when she travels with a driver who is a member of a local taxi service.¹⁰

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SHABBOS-RELATED MATTERS

1 The mikvah is scheduled to be used on Friday night as well as immediately after Shabbos. May I ask a goy to turn on the filter on Shabbos?

A: The correct procedure is to have the filter running on an automatic timer, set to turn on the filter on Shabbos morning. If the timer was somehow turned off, you may ask a goy to turn the timer back on, so that the timer will activate the filtering process on its own. You may also ask the goy to adjust the timing on the timer as necessary. If there is no timer, it is generally forbidden to ask the goy to turn on the filter.¹¹ However, if you are certain that the mikvah is meant to be used immediately after Shabbos, and you know that the person in question will likely not immerse in a mikvah that is not heated, and this situation will serve as a *mechushel*, a rov should be contacted¹² so as to determine whether you can rely upon those who are more lenient and allow for a goy to turn on the filter *be'shminui* and *le'achar yd*.¹³ The above-described solutions are also to be used in the event that the mikvah is scheduled to be used on *motzoei Shabbos* and it is discovered on Shabbos morning that the

water is cold.

2 I arrived at the mikvah on Friday night only to find that the lights were turned off. What should I do?

A: It is not permitted to ask a goy to turn on the lights because *אין מתירין שבות אפילו*.¹⁴ If there are lit candles somewhere nearby, a goy may be asked to bring them (while they are still lit) to the mikvah. In a dire circumstance, a rov may be consulted¹² as to whether one can rely upon those who permit a *litzur* *מצוה*.¹³

3 I arrived at the mikvah on Friday night only to find the mikvah water freezing cold. What should I do?

A: If the woman is willing to use cold water, as long as the *mashgicha* is there to ensure that the woman has *toiveled* properly, *tevila* under such conditions is permissible. However, if she is afraid of the cold and does not want to delay the *tevila*, if the hot water faucet flows directly into the mikvah (and the water is not warmed by turning on the filter), a goy may be asked to turn it on.¹⁴ If the water is warmed by turning on the filter, consult a rov.¹²

4 A not-yet-shomeres Shabbos wishes to use the mikvah on Friday night. In doing so, there is a chance that she will perform *melochos* such as driving to and from the mikvah or using hot water for cleaning purposes. What should I do?



Mikvah Mei Menachem in Riga, Latvia. See story on page 78.

A: In this case, the woman is coming on her own accord and decides when to come and from where. It is not your responsibility to question her as to how she got to the mikvah. It is important, however, that you make it possible for her to use the mikvah without *chilul Shabbos*. If she lives farther than walking distance,

you can invite her and her husband to stay nearby. You should also instruct her to do *chafifa* before Shabbos and encourage her to make her final preparations in a halachically permissible manner. **C**

WRITTEN BY MRS. ELKY RAITPORT

תפחד לעמוד על הכלים אולי תיפול, ומפני טרדת הפחד לא תטבול יפה. 9. כמבואר בדברי הריב"ש סי' תכה. 10. ראה שו"ת אג"מ יו"ד ח"ב סי' פב ואבה"ע סי' סה אות ג.

11. ראה שו"ת סי' רעו ס"ח, שפוסק כדברי האומרים שאין להתיר שבות במקום מצוה אפילו לצורך גדול.

12. In the event that your circumstances make it impossible for you to contact a rov on Shabbos, it is important that you pre-empt these possibilities and pose these questions to a rov at your earliest opportunity as the answers to these questions are case-specific.

13. עיין שו"ת מהרש"ם ח"ח סי' מ ומשנה ברורה רעו ס"ק כה.

14. כיון שהכנסת המים הקרים הוא פסיק רישא שהותר באמירה לנכרי בפרט לצורך מצות טבילה.

3. ראה שו"ת סי' רא סל"ו וברמ"א סעי' ס"ו דלכתחילה שיעור גובה המים הוא "גבוה ממעל לטבורה זרת", ולרוב הפוסקים שיעור זרת הוא ג' טפחים.

4. If, however, the בור הטבילה and the pool of rainwater are side by side (השקה מן הצד), it is absolutely imperative that the mikvah is filled to the normal level, so as to connect with the rainwater pool via the *shikva* aperture.

5. עיי' שו"ת סי' קצז סל"ז, וברמ"א סי' רא סעי' ס"ו, ובדברי אדמו"ר בתיקון מקוה שלו, ועיי' שו"ת אג"מ יו"ד ח"א סי' קן.

6. ראה טהרה כהלכה פ"כ סעי' קכט והמצויין שם.

7. ועיין שו"ת הל' נטילת ידים סי' קנח סט"ז והשווה לכאן.

8. ראה שו"ת סי' קצח סל"א עיי"ש הפרטים, ויש בזה פרטים: א) דיני כלים המקבלים טומאה; ב) חשש שמא

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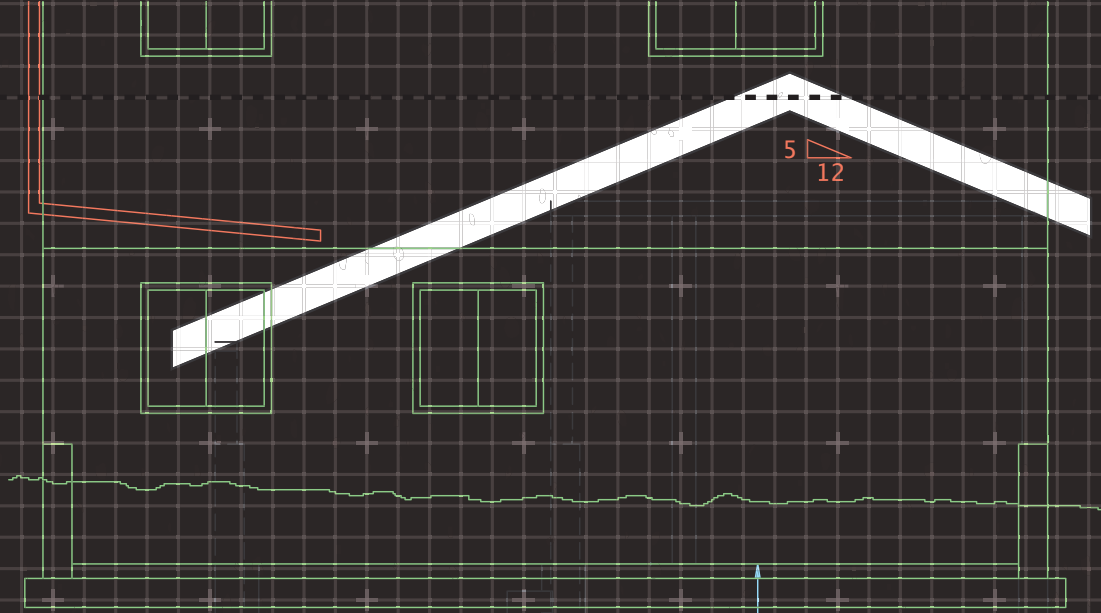
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ARE YOU READY TO BUILD A MIKVAH?



POINTS TO
CONSIDER

8'-10"

6"

After paying an expensive airline ticket and flying to the nearest mikvah some two hours away, a shlucha arrived to find that the bor hatevila was completely empty. With ½ an hour left before she needed to leave to the airport in order to catch the last flight of the day back to her hometown, she called a rov to find out what is the minimum amount of water necessary to facilitate kosher tevila.

Another shlucha flew to the nearest city with a mikvah, only to be stranded there for two days due to a blizzard.

Yet a third shlucha found herself stuck at the side of the road after her car broke down en-route the three hour drive to the mikvah one late summer's evening. The car was finally fixed at 11:30 pm, by which time the attendant in the next city had long gone home. With her husband at home with six children and no babysitter to come by, she called a rov to inquire as to whether she might be able to go without a mashgicha.

Although there is a great achrayus that comes along with having a mikvah under your care, the many difficult

questions that arise when there is no mikvah nearby are far greater. Boruch Hashem, in recent years, shluchim the world over have garnered the courage and means to build mikvaos much more quickly than in previous years. Indeed, as we tell our baalei batim, the mikvah is the foundation of the Jewish home and family and the source of many brochos. The Rebbe strongly emphasized the need for shluchim to invest themselves into building not just kosher but beautiful mikvaos, even if just for the individual shluchos (and the shluchos in the neighboring towns, states or countries) themselves.

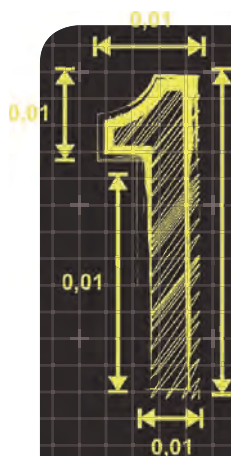
When building a mikvah, the primary goal should be to make it as inviting as possible, setting a woman at ease from the moment she enters the parking lot. It has been proven time and again that shluchim who build mikvaos that are not just "adequate," but beautiful, see women who they never dreamed would consider doing this mitzvah become frequent mikvah users. Though some may be daunted by the prospects of finding the funds and being responsible for what has been pre conceived to be a highly complicated project, this article will serve as a brief outline

to let you know what is actually involved in building a mikvah and will hopefully help you find that it is indeed within your reach to do so. Though it is a costly project, the dividends are priceless.

THE DOLLARS AND SENSE

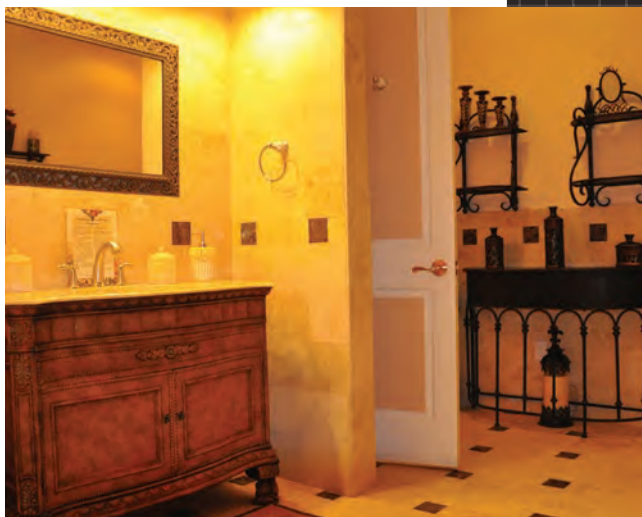
The cost of building a mikvah varies, often ranging between \$100,000-\$140,000. Though it may be tempting to set construction into motion once a portion of the money has been raised, Rabbi Grossbaum strongly cautions against doing so. Though for some, this will make it easier to motivate baalei batim to donate, his vast experience of assisting shluchim in the mikvah building process has seen too many a shliach get tripped up and have his project be permanently interrupted.

No two mikvah construction projects are the same. However, considering the answers to the following questions may assist you in determining what you actually need and how much it is likely to end up costing you.



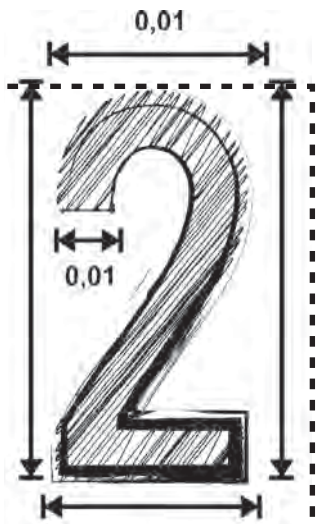
PREP ROOMS

For a mikvah with up to 20 monthly mikvah users, one prep room is sufficient. Though a second prep room would be preferred if anticipating 30-35 users, one prep room can still suffice. For 35-70 monthly users, two prep rooms should be built. An additional prep room should be built for each additional 35 monthly projected users. It is highly recommended to design the mikvah with one more prep room than you presently project needing, leaving it unfinished if so desired. B'eZRas Hashem you will see an increased number of mikvah users and come to need the additional prep room in the not-so-distant future.



The prep rooms at the mikvah in Jacksonville, Florida are beautiful and inviting.

"Even an unnecessary chair leaning against the wall of the mikvah room may cause a woman discomfort..."



**IS THERE ANYTHING
I CAN DO WHILE
I'M WORKING ON
RAISING FUNDS?**

If you have fully committed yourself to getting the mikvah built, you can already work on drawing the plans. It will give you what to show to baalei batim and provide a clearer picture of how much the project will actually cost. You can borrow an architect's concept from another shliach or have your baal habos contractor help you come up with your own (though he will not be the contractor you use for the job). Though you may not actually follow through with those plans in the end, the concept will still be the same and no donor will complain.

MEN'S USAGE

If the men's usage will typically be limited to the shliach and his sons, no extra mikvah or prep rooms are needed. If, however, the shliach projects that a number of baalei batim will use the mikvah as well, a men's prep room should be built. This prep room does not need to feature all the amenities typically found in a women's prep room and will cost considerably less to build. If more than 12 men will be using the mikvah on an ongoing basis, it is strongly recommended that a separate men's mikvah be built.

Regardless of the volume or frequency of men's usage, it is exceedingly crucial that the prep rooms and mikvah room be thoroughly cleaned after every male use. It is of utmost importance that every woman who visits the mikvah be pleased with its state of cleanliness and aesthetics; even an unnecessary chair leaning against the wall of the mikvah room may cause a woman discomfort, never mind the knowledge that men are also making use of this facility.



תכלית הנקיות והיופי

כידוע דער סיפור פון דעם רבי'ן נ"ע, אז אמאל איז ער געגאנגען אין מקוה אין ראסטאב, און האט געפונען אז עס שווימט א פאר האר אויף די וואסער, האט ער אריינגערופן דעם בעדער וואס האט געהאלטן די מקוה, און האט אים געזאגט, אז אים (דעם רבי'ן נ"ע) ארט דאס ניט, ער זאל אבער וויסן זיין דעם גודל האחריות וואס איז דא אין דערויף, ווארום עס קען זיין אז אין און איינציקע פרוי וועט ניט וועלן גיין אין מקוה, דערפאר וואס זי האט דארטן געפונען אז ס'שווימען א פאר האר, אדער אן אנדער ענין פון העדר הנקיות, און אפי' העדר היופי - זאל ער וויסן די אחריות וואס ער נעמט אויף זיך דורך דערויף וואס ער באווארענט דאס ניט.

וואס אויב ס'איז געווען אזוי במדינה ההיא, און מיט עשיריות שנים לפני - איז עאכט"כ ווען מ'געפינט זיך אין מדינות הרוחה, און בא זיך אין דער היים איז מען אייגענוואוינט צו תכלית הנקיות והיופי וכו', דארף מען זעהן אז די מקוה טהרה

[וואס דארטן ווערט געלייגט דער יסוד אז די אייגענע הויז זאל זיין שיין באמיתיות וברוחניות - דורך דערויף וואס מ'בויט א מקוה טהרה, און מ'נוצט איר בשמחה ובטוב לבב]

זאל זיין בתכלית הזהירות והדיק, און טאן כל האופנים האפשריים אויף צוציען אהינצו מענטשן - דורך דעם וואס דער קיום המצוה וועט קענען זיין מתוך שמחה וטוב לבב, וויבאלד אז דער גוף ונה"ב וועלן דאס אויך וועלן טאן.

(משיחת אור ל"ד כסלו תשל"ט)

The Rebbe Rashab once visited the mikvah in Rostov and was dismayed to find a couple of hairs floating on the water. The Rebbe Rashab called the caretaker and told him that although these hairs did not bother the Rebbe Rashab personally, the caretaker should be aware of the great achra-yus resting on his shoulders should even one woman resist using the mikvah due to those hairs or other lack of cleanliness—or even a lack of aesthetics.

If this is so in that country so many years ago, how much more so does this apply nowadays, and in a country of plenty. People are accustomed to their homes being absolutely clean and beautiful. We must ensure that the mikvah, the foundation upon which the true and spiritual beauty of a home rests, be immaculately maintained, so that it be used with joy. All possible methods to draw people to it should be employed, for when the physical body and animalistic soul will also desire to perform this mitzvah, it will be performed with joy and gladness of heart.

(Free translation of a sicha excerpt from the eve of the 14th of Kislev, 5739)

דריי כשר'ע קינדער

עס איז ניט געווען קיין געלט, ניט קיין ברויט. מען האט זיך געלאזט אין וועג אריין מיט מס"ג, יעדער אין א באזונדער געגנט. איינער פון זיי איז געקומען אין אן ארט אין קאווקאז, וואו עס איז ניט געווען קיין מקוה. האט ער זיך פארגעשטעלט אלס שליח פון מאסקווער מרכז (מיר האבן אויך געהאט א מרכז אין מאסקווע). זיי האבן געמיינט אז דאס איז פון זייער מרכז. דארט איז געווען א ספאלקאם, האט ער דארט אויפגעפאדערט מען זאל מאכן א מקוה, מען דארף זיך ניט אויסשליסן פון כלל ישראל. האט מען געמאכט אן אסיפה. איינער האט געגעבן האלץ, איינער ארבעט, אין משך פון צען טעג איז געווען א מקוה. דערנאך האבן זיי אפגעשיקט א רעפארט אין מאסקווא פון דער גאנצער זאך. עס האט ניט לאנג געדויערט און במשך פון צוויי חדשים פארמאכט. אונז איז דאס ניט געווען נוגע. מיר האבן געטאן וואס מיר האבן געקענט. טאמער זיינען געגאנגען דריי ווייבער אין מקוה און עס איז געבארן געווארן דריי כשר'ע קינדער איז אויך כדאי.

(משיחת י"ג תמוז תרצ"ב בדרוסקעניק, נדפס בתשורה ממשפחת גליק)

There was no money, there was no bread. People ventured out with mesiras nefesh, every person in another neighborhood. One person arrived to an area in the Caucasian mountains where there was no mikvah. He presented himself as a representative sent by the main [KGB] office in Moscow. (Truthfully, we, too, had an office in Moscow.) They [the local KGB officers] thought that he was from their headquarters. There, there was an executive committee and he insisted that they build a mikvah; after all, [he said,] we don't have to exclude ourselves from Klal Yisroel completely. They held a meeting and one person donated wood, one donated labor, and within ten days there was a mikvah. Then, they sent a report to Moscow. After two months, the mikvah was shut down. This did not concern us; we had done what we were able to do. If three women used the mikvah and three kosher children were born, it was all worth it.

(Free translation of an excerpt from a sicha of the Friediker Rebbe on 13 Tammuz, 5692 in Druskenik. Printed in a teshura of the Glick family.)

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SIZE

An average-sized mikvah with one prep room, a small entry room and a small mechanical closet typically needs 350-500 square feet, depending on the shape of the space. Each additional prep room will need approximately 150 square feet. (In a pinch, the entire mikvah facility can be built on 200 square feet, though it will obviously be more modest in style.) If purchasing a separate facility, the costs of doing so should obviously be added to the figures mentioned above.



Preparing the formwork for Mikvah Mei Chaya Mushka in Aspen, Colorado.



COST EFFECTIVE? THE REBBE'S RESPONSE

By the mid 1980s, most of East Flatbush's Jewish residents had relocated to safer neighborhoods. Rabbi Michael Teitelbaum was one of the very last, if not the last, Jew to staunchly remain, firmly adhering to the Rebbe's hora'ah that the Bnei Avraham shul continue to stay in operation. At that time, only one woman was using the neighborhood mikvah, prompting Rabbi Teitelbaum to consider closing it. When presenting his consideration to the Rebbe, the Rebbe succinctly responded,

"אם אחת היתה למשה רבנו."

Moshe Rabbeinu had
one mother.



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com, a database of over 1,000 profiles of Anash
singles. We are very grateful to Moshe Reichman of
ChabadMatch.com for his tireless efforts in helping
us set up this website, allowing shluchim to enjoy a
system that has helped bring about more than 150
engagements.



SPOT CHECK SURPRISE

A young man who frequented the Chabad House of Rabbi Ari and Mrs. Shterna Raskin in Brooklyn Heights was engaged to a young woman from elsewhere.

When invited to officiate at the wedding, Rabbi Raskin agreed on condition that the kallah would use the mikvah before the wedding. Rabbi Raskin provided the kallah with his wife's contact information and reassured her that his wife would walk her through the whole process.

A few short days before the wedding, the kallah called Rabbi Raskin. She explained that

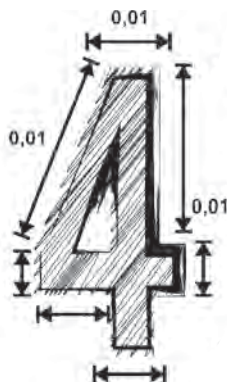
ON THE DAY OF THE WEDDING, THE KALLAH INFORMED RABBI RASKIN THAT SHE HAD USED THE MIKVAH THE NIGHT BEFORE BUT WOULD NEVER USE A MIKVAH AGAIN.

she had just found out that her grandfather had endowed a mikvah in New Jersey and was asking permission to use that mikvah instead of going with

Mrs. Raskin to the mikvah in Brooklyn Heights. Rabbi Raskin agreed.

On the day of the wedding, the kallah informed Rabbi Raskin that she had used the mikvah the night before but would never use a mikvah again. She described the mikvah as being decrepit and dirty with mold growing on the walls.

Fast forward a number of years. The same woman called Rabbi Raskin and excitedly informed him that he now has three new customers for his mikvah. "My two friends and I were having coffee near your mikvah," she explained, "and we decided to go check it out ourselves." The beauty and fine design of the mikvah and its facilities so impressed the women and inspired them to take on the mitzvah.

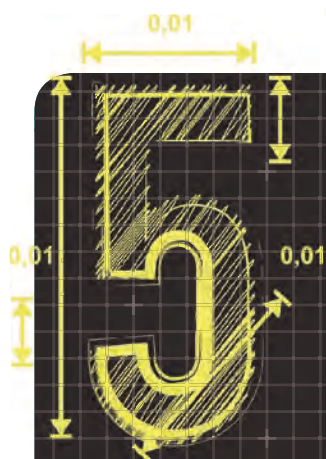


ARCHITECTURE

If your building is considered by the city to be a public facility, you will need an architect to sign off on the project. The architect's fees will amount to approximately 8-10% of the project's costs. If the mikvah will be constructed as an addition to your home or (non-public) facility, the city will usually approve it without an architect on board. Still, you may wish to consider hiring an architect in any case so as to maximize the potential of your project from a design perspective.

Find Out About the Funds

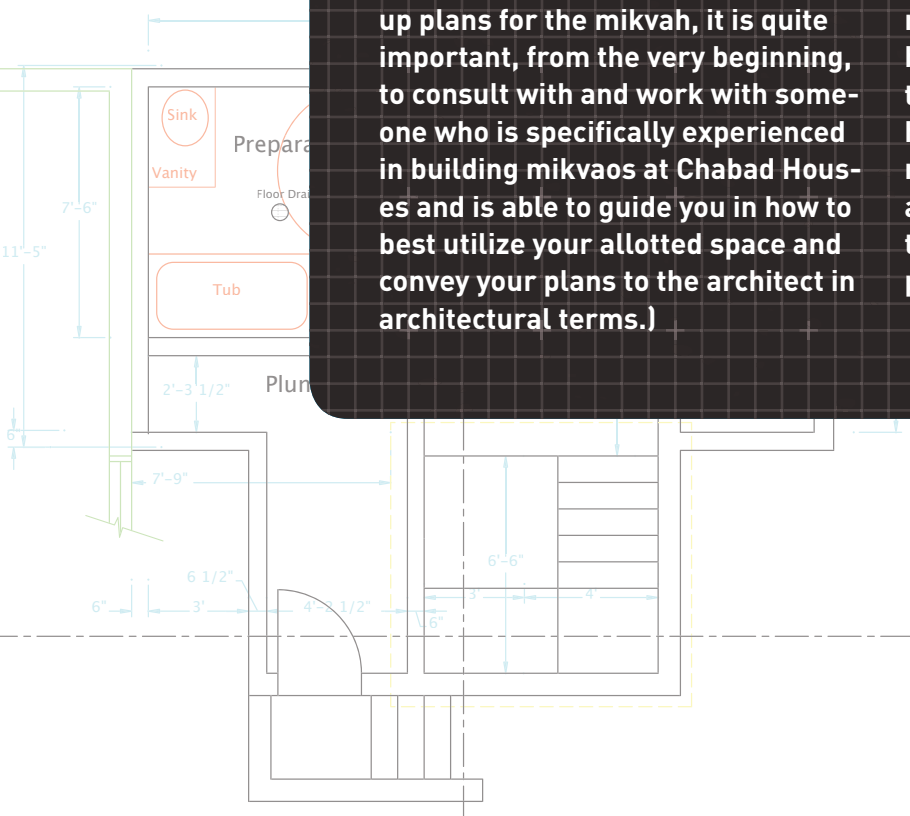
There are several organizations that give money toward mikvaos. Before approaching these organizations for funds, it may be to your benefit to speak with other shlichim about their experiences in order to determine which organization's criteria you will reasonably be able to fulfill.



THE *REAL* COST OF USING A BAAL HABOS' SERVICES

Theoretically, a shliach who is relatively competent in this field and is able to completely devote himself to this project can be his own contractor, significantly reducing the cost. However, this is not usually the case. Therefore, if he cannot be his own contractor and does not know of any contractors, he will need an architect to draw up plans so that all prospective contractors bid on the same project. (It should be noted that when drawing up plans for the mikvah, it is quite important, from the very beginning, to consult with and work with someone who is specifically experienced in building mikvaos at Chabad Houses and is able to guide you in how to best utilize your allotted space and convey your plans to the architect in architectural terms.)

Though donations of materials can ease the cost, it is not recommended for shluchim to use their baalei batim as contractors, especially if the baal habos has offered to undertake this project pro bono or at a significantly reduced price. Regardless of what type of mikvah you plan to build, it will almost always turn out to be a larger-scale project than what the baal habos has anticipated and runs the risk of him pulling out midway, losing you a baal habos in the process. Additionally, it is much more complicated to approach a baal habos in the event that something goes awry. The baal habos can, however, serve as a terrific owner's representative and right hand man, and, of course, donations of raw materials can help ease the cost of the project.



Satisfied With a Ruby?

The mikvah in Riga, Latvia was built with mesiras nefesh by Lubavitcher Chassidim under the noses of the Soviets over 50 years ago. Situated in

the basement of the city's shul, the mikvah and its preparation room consisted of two bathtubs sitting side by side, inches away from the הטבילה בור.

Though the mikvah was renovated in 1992 by Riga's rabbi at that time, Rabbi Nota Barkhan a"h, the fact that it was in the basement of the shul meant that the room was constantly humid, the paint was always peeling, and that there was no privacy when events took place in the shul during the evenings. Additionally, the fact that the shul is located in the Old City meant that users could not drive to the mikvah and had to walk significant distances on cobblestone streets in order to come. Additionally, very often the city would close the hot water in the old city for months on end, leading to unbelievable difficulties. That the mikvah was being used by a handful of women was impressive.

In 5761, Riga shluchim Rabbi Mordechai and Mrs. Rivki Glazman felt that it was time for a change. Thanks to the generous grants they received from Mr. and Mrs. George Rohr, Rabbi and Rebbetzin Yitzchak Raitport, and the Yad Mordechai Foundation, they bought a building in the more modern part of the city and built a beautiful mikvah. With people in Riga still living in Soviet apartments, the uniformly colored tiles and covered pipes make it a sight to see, never mind the upscale design and furnishings that have become the accepted standard at mikvaos around the world.

The mikvah now sees 30-40 monthly users, boruch Hashem, and the beauty of the mikvah is the talk of town. Mrs. Glazman frequently takes local teens on mikvah tours. "They're so excited to see it and say they look forward to using it as brides and after marriage," she says.

Reflecting on her initial thoughts when her husband raised the subject of building a new women's mikvah, bor al gabei bor, Mrs. Glazman admits she was uncertain. After all, she thought, the city already possessed a mikvah and the money could just as well be spent on other initiatives. Her mashpia's advice helped her make the decision. "If someone is offering you a genuine diamond, how can you be satisfied with a ruby?"

און פארט צוויי טויזנט קילאמעטער, כדי מ'זאל זיך שטעלן די פראגע-שאלה: אט האט איר א פאטאגראפיע פון א מקוה, און אט האט איר א פאטאגראפיע פון ישיבה; וויפל קינדער אויף דיין בלאק גייען ניט אין קיין ישיבה? האסט מיט זיי גערעדט וועגן דעם? גערעדט מיטן פאטער? גערעדט מיטן מוטער? איז מען געפאלן אויף דער המצאה: זיי רעכנען אז דאס מיינט מען וואס ס'טוט זיך מעבר לים. זאל מען ניט איינרעדן זיך קיין חלומות; דאס מיינט מען "בתוך עמי אנכי יושבת":

דאס איז דא פופציק "סטייטס" אין "יוניטעד סטייטס", בכל סטייט וסטייט איז דא אידן. איז דא אן "איגוד" פון רבנים, אן "אגודת הרבנים", "ועד הרבנים" – דארפן זיי טאקע באזארגן אז טאמער געפינט זיך א איד פאר דריי טויזנט קילאמעטער, זאל זיין פרוי גיין אין מקוה, און דער אינגל זאל לערנען אין ישיבה; אבער לכל לראש דארף ער דאך באווארענען "עניי עירך".

און ס'פאלט גאר ניט איין אז מ'האט געדארפט רעדן וועגן דעם. און וואס וועל איך אויפטאן מיט מיין רעדן? איך וועל זיך פאררייסן מיט די אלע וואס האבן געמאכט די אסיפות, וואס צווישן זיי איז דא זייער פיינע אידן, און יראי שמים און גוטע פריינט, אלע גוטע מעלות. און אט דא זעט מען אויף וויפל דער העולם והסתר העולם איז גרויס: א דבר גלוי, ס'איז ניטא קיין אנדער ביאור, קיין אנדער תועלת, אין דעם באווייזן די פאטאגראפיע. כ'מין, ער איז ניט קיין נאר און ווייסט ער נארט קיינעם ניט אפ, נאר ער האט קיין ברירה ניט, "מצווה ועומד". דער שואל ווייסט, אז ניט יענער האט א טעות, ניט ער וויל אים מטעה זיין; ס'איז מערניט וואס מ'טוט דאס "הם לא עשו אלא לפנים".

דארף ער אים שטעלן די פראגע, און "אשר ישים אלקים בפי אותו אדבר": דאס איז ניט ער שטעלט די פראגע, נאר וואס דען? ער מיינט אז ער איז געפאלן אויף דער המצאה און האט געפרעדט ביי יענעם; דאס "פרעגט מען" מלמעלה ביי אים! איז דאך לכאורה, פארוואס נוצסטו דאס ניט אויס באווארענען "עניי עירך"? דיר טוט ווי די הארץ פאר דארטן? ס'איז על-פי תורה אזוי, דארף ווי טאן די הארץ. און ווי דער בעל הגאולה שרייבט: ס'דארף ווי טאן די הארץ פונקט ווי דאס ווארט רח"ל געטראפן מיט זיינעם א קינד, אז ער קען ניט באקומען קיין חינוך. אבער דאס באפרייט דאך אים ניט, אז אים זאל ניט ווי טאן פאר זיין אייגענעם קינד. איז דאס ניט זיין "אייגענער קינד" בנפש – איז דאס פון זיין קהילה, איז דאס פון זיינע ד' אמות, איז דאס פון זיין "בלאק", איז דאס פון זיין שטאט.

וכמובאר כמה פעמים: ס'איז אין כוונתי עובר זיין אויפן ציווי אז "אין צועקען על העבר". ס'איז דאך נאך ניט "עבר"; מ'קען אנהויבן פון היינט אן צו רעדן אין דעם: זאל מען ארויסגיין, שטעלן זיך אויף דער בימה אין א שול און זאגן: הערז זיך איין אידן, ס'איז דא אן ארט וואס פופציק יאר נאכאנאנד טאר מען ניט לערנען און מ'טאר דאס ניט טאן וכו' וכו', וכל הפרטים, מאריך זיין, אדער מאכן דאס בקיצור וועט זיין געזינטער.

און דערנאך מסיים זיין: אשר לכן אידן, איז כל-שכן וקל-וחומר, בשעת איין האט דער אויבערשטער געבענטשט און מצליח געווען, אז איר געפינט זיך אין א מדינה וואס מ'מעג לערנען, און מ'מעג מחנך זיין קינדער, און מ'מעג דרוקן ספרים, און מ'מעג לערנען ספרים, און מ'מעג געבן אויף צדקה, און דאס קענען די אלע ענינים טאן בריש גלי – דאנקט דעם אויבערשטן יעדער טאג פארוואס איר מעגט מחנך זיין די קינדער על טהרת הקודש, און טוט דאס אז די ברכה זאל שורה זיין: פון מארגן אינדערפרי שיקט אוועק "בנערינו ובזקנינו... בבנינו ובבנותינו" אין בתי-ספר וואס מ'וועט מיט זיי אנהויבן לערנען "אלף-בית" פון אידישקייט.

(משיחת קודש י"ב תמוז תשכ"ח)





JEM / The Living Archive #108692

Rabbi Yehuda Leib Levin, Moscow's chief rabbi, was sent by the Soviet government to the United States to assure the West that Soviet Jewry faces no discrimination and is free to practice its religion. Rabbi Levin was accompanied by minders who listened to his every word. Despite his own convictions, during a speaking engagement in New York, he displayed photographs of Jewish institutions in Moscow as evidence that Soviet Jewry was thriving. He was challenged by some members of his audience and accorded a hostile reception by some Jewish leaders who saw his presentation as counterproductive to the cause of Soviet Jewry. The Rebbe, understanding his predicament, saw the matter in a very different light.

SEE NEXT PAGE FOR ENGLISH TRANSLATION.



וואס טוט זיך פון יענער זייט טיר?

מען על-פי דין ניט פרעגן. ס'איז מערניט אויף געזען זיין א אידן. און פונקט אזוי ווי מ'טאר ניט מזמין זיין איינעם צו א סעודה, בשעת מ'ווייס אז יענער וועט ניט קומען – אט אזוי טאר מען ניט פרעגן קיין שאלה אז מ'ווייסט אז יענער וועט ניט ענטפערן. און יענער טאר ניט ענטפערן, ס'איז אן ענין וואס קיין תועלת וועט אין דערויף ניט זיין, און סכנה קען אין דערויף זיין.

צוליב וואס איז געווען די גאנצע שאלה? מ'האט געפרעגט ניט וועגן דער מקוה דארטן; מ'האט געפרעגט וועגן דער מקוה אין קאנעטיקעט, און וועגן דער מקוה אין מינעאפאליס. ס'איז דא א פאטאגראפיע פון דער מקוה; האט מען געפרעגט ביי דעם מנהל רוחני; וואס טוט זיך פון יענער זייט טיר? וויפל פרויען גייען דארטן מידי שבוע בשבוע? די פאטאגראפיע איז זייער א האט מען געפרעגט ביי יענעם אידן מעבר לים, וואס טוט זיך מעבר לים פון יענער זייט טיר – דאס פרעגט ער ביי זיך אליין; האט א מקוה ביי זיך אין שטאט? וואס טוט זיך פון יענער זייט טיר?

ביסטו געגאנגען ווי די סנהדרין גדולה האט געטאן? "קושרין שלשלאות של ברזל במתניהם ומחזרין בכל גבולות ישראל" און מ'לערנט מיט זיי אידישקייט. באווייזן א טיר פון א ישיבה?

דאס מיינען מען די ישיבות דא. ס'איז א הצלחה גדולה, ס'איז ניתוסף געווארן אזויפיל קינדער. וויפל קינדער גייען ניט אין קיין ישיבה? אט די וואס גייען אין ישיבה – תבוא עליהם ברכה, איז "הקטן יהיה לאלף והצעיר לגוי עצום", און ס'וועט זיין "בעתה אחישנה", אלע גוטע יעודים. קומט צופארן א איד

אויס אז ס'דארף זיין דינו כן וכך. לאחר איז ס'גייט דורך כמה שנים, און ביי אים טרעפט זיך די זעלבע זאך – אט דעמאלט איז דאס "שלא מדעתו", ער שרייט ככרוכיא. זאגט מען אים: פאר דערויף איז אבער געווען דער "נפרעין מדעתו" – דו אליין האסט גע'פסק'נט, אז בשעת ס'וועט זיין אזא מין ענין, אט דאס זאל זיין דער דין.

האט דער אויבערשטער דען געהאלפן, און דער איד וואס לכבודו האט מען געמאכט די אסיפה, האט זיך אוועקגעשטעלט און האט באווייזן א תמונה פון א טיר פון א ישיבה, און פון א טיר פון א מקוה. האט מען אים געפרעגט: וואס טוט זיך פון יענער זייט טיר? האט מען אים פארשאפט עגמת-נפש: ער ווייס וואס ס'טוט זיך אין יענער זייט טיר, דער שוואל ווייסט אויכעט.

צוליב וואס האט דאס דער אויבערשטער באשאפן א מצב מ'זאל מצער זיין איין אידן, און פרעגן א שאלה? וואס על-פי דין, א שאלה וואס ער ווייסט די תשובה אויף אידן, און ווייסט אז יענער קען ניט ענטפערן – טאר

דאך דא די תורת הבעל שם טוב אויף "נפרעין מן האדם מדעתו ושלא מדעתו": איז דאך דא אין דערויף דער דיוק – וואס הייסט דאס "מדעתו ושלא מדעתו"? ערשטנס זעט מען במציאות, אז "נפרעין מן האדם" און ס'איז בפירוש ניט "מדעתו" – ער שרייט ככרוכיא אז ער וויל ניט דעם עונש; איז וואס הייסט "מדעתו"? און וואו האט מען דאס געזען אז א איד זאל מסכים זיין אז מ'זאל אים מעניש זיין? ס'איז בפירוש "שלא מדעתו"!

טייטש אפ דער בעל שם טוב: אזוי ווי דער אויבערשטער וויל דאך באווארענען אז ס'זאל זיין א דין צדק מכל הצדדים, איז ער מזמין אט דעם אידן אזא מין מקרה דומה, נאר וואס דען? וואס ס'האט געטראפן ביי א צווייטן. און דערנאך פירט מען ארויף אז איינער זאל מעורר זיין ביי דעם אידן; ווי קומט ביי דיר אויס, אזוי ווי דו זעסט דאך פלוגי בן פלוגי האט געטאן אזא מין זאך, וואס קומט אים? זאגט ער, אז ביי אים קומט

The Baal Shem Tov quotes the Mishna, “Payment is exacted from a person with his consent or without it.” What does this mean? When payment is exacted, when a person is punished, it is always without his consent. Who desires punishment? Have you ever seen anyone “consent” to being punished? It is clearly without his consent!

The Baal Shem Tov interprets: Since G-d wants to ensure that His punishment will be truly just, He brings before a person a case similar to his, but as it occurred to someone else. Then G-d causes him to be asked the question: “What’s your opinion? You see that so-and-so did such a terrible thing. What do you think he deserves?” He states his judgement that so-and-so deserves a certain consequence. Several years pass, and he finds himself in a similar situation, but when he’s dealt the same consequences, he objects! He’s then told, “Payment is being exacted with your consent—you yourself passed judgement that for a sin like this, such and such a punishment be given.

Now G-d has caused it, that the rabbi in whose honor a gathering was made stood up and displayed a picture of a door to a yeshiva, and of a door to a mikvah. He was asked: “But what’s going on the other side of the door?” The question only caused him anguish. He knows what’s going on the other side, and the questioner knows it, as well!

Now, why would G-d create a situation in which a Jew is caused nothing but anguish by such a question? Jewish law states that if one knows the answer to a question, and knows that the other person is unable to answer it, it is for-

bidden to ask it. Just as it is forbidden to invite someone to a meal when one knows that he will not come, so is it forbidden to ask a question that someone can’t answer. And in this case, he *could not* answer! There was absolutely no point to it, and it might have literally put him in danger. So why did the whole question come up?

The real question wasn’t about the mikvah in Russia, the real question was about your mikvah in New York! The question cried out about the mikvah in Connecticut, and about the mikvah in Minneapolis. There may be a photograph of the mikvah, but the spiritual leader is being asked, what happens on the other side of the door? How many women use it each week? The photograph is very nice, and the mikvah is most probably kosher.

You ask *someone else* about a mikvah overseas—“what’s going on on the other side of the door, across the ocean?” In reality, you’re asking *yourself* that question: You have a mikvah in your city? What’s going on on the other side of *that* door? Have you been trekking around, as the Great Sanhedrin would—“They girded their loins with iron chains, and went throughout the Jewish lands” teaching them about Judaism.

You’re asking about the door to a yeshiva in Russia?! You’re passing judgement on the Jewish schools here. Yes, there’s been great success, and so many new children have enrolled. But how many



The Goldmans celebrate the opening of their mikvah in Gainesville, Florida.

You came up with a challenge, and you think you are making a statement about Jewish education overseas. Stop dreaming. You’re making a statement about your very community.

children don’t attend a Jewish school? Those who do attend Jewish schools should be blessed: “May the small turn into a thousand, and the youth into a great nation,” and all the prophecies will be fulfilled. A Jew travelled two thousand kilometres, in order to pose the question to *you*: Yes, you have a photograph of a mikvah and here’s a Jewish school, but how many children on your own block *don’t* attend a Jewish school? Did you speak with them about it? Did you speak with the father? Did you speak with the mother?

You came up with a challenge, and you think you are making a statement about Jewish education overseas. Stop dreaming. You’re making a statement about your very

community. There are fifty states in the United States and there are Jews living in every single state. True, there are various rabbinic boards and committees and it is, in fact, their job to ensure that a Jew living somewhere three thousand kilometres away, his wife should go to mikvah, and their child should attend a Jewish school. Still, first and foremost, care for the “destitute souls” in your own city.

But it doesn’t occur to anyone to discuss this. What will my discussing this matter accomplish, other than to upset all those who called the meetings? Among whom are very fine, G-d-fearing Jews and good friends of mine, with fine qualities. This shows just how superficial the world we live

in is: Clearly, the only reason he displayed the photograph.... This rabbi is no fool, and he knows that he's fooling no one, but he has no choice—he was instructed to do so by the Soviet government. You know the rabbi is not misinformed, nor does he seek to deceive anyone; he is doing only it for show. So you asked him the question, but you're speaking the words that G-d placed in your mouth, it's not your question. You think it's your question, but in reality, G-d is asking this question of *you!* Why don't you see this as a message to look after your own? You feel distressed about what's happening there?

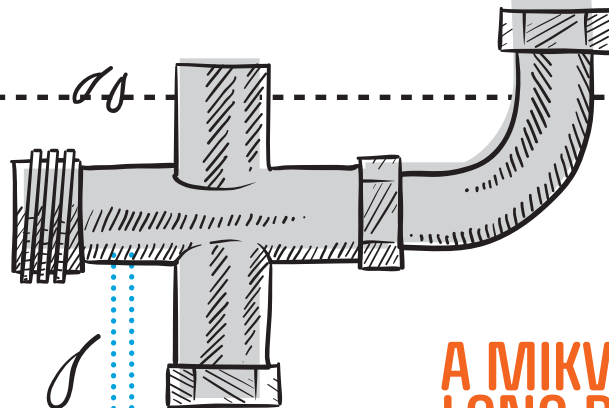
This is proper according to Torah—you *should* feel distress. And as the Rebbe, my father-in-law writes: One's heart should be pained just as if it were one's own child who could not receive a Jewish education. But this doesn't exempt you from being pained by your own child, not your biological child, but a member of your own community, in your own immediate surroundings, on your block, from your city.

As I've often explained, I don't mean to violate the injunction of not crying over the past. It's not the past—you can begin talking about it from now on. Go out, stand up on the podium in synagogue, and say: "Listen up! There's a place where for fifty years Jews are prohibited from studying Torah, and observing mitzvos, and so on...." Elaborate on the details or make it briefer, whichever you prefer, but then conclude: "Therefore, Jews, how much more so you here—G-d has blessed you, and you find yourselves in a country where you may study Torah, where you are allowed to educate your children with Torah, we are allowed to print Torah books, to study Torah books, to donate charity, and we are able to do all these things openly.

Thank G-d every day that you can raise your children with a real Jewish education, and do all you can so that blessing will rest upon them. From tomorrow and on, send "your young and your old, your sons and your daughters" to schools in which they can learn the basics of Judaism.

(Excerpt from a sicha on 12 Tammuz, 5728)

FREE TRANSLATION COURTESY OF JEM



A MIKVAH FOR LONG BEACH

Following the N'shei Ubnos Chabad Convention in Los Angeles, California in 5732, Mrs. Popack traveled to Long Beach to spend time with her daughter and son-in-law, Rabbi Ephraim and Mrs. Chana Piekarski, and their children, who had then served as the shlichim there. While she was there, Rafi Katz, a young man of Mizrahi affiliation who lived in Long Beach, joined the family for a Shabbos meal. Thoroughly impressed by the Piekarskis' shlichus activities, the young man commented that "everything is good here, but we have no mikvah."

Upon returning from her trip, Mrs. Popack wrote a duch to the Rebbe. She shared the latest developments in Long Beach and also included the comment that was made by the young Mizrahi visitor. That very day, Rabbi Piekarski received a phone call from Rabbi Binyomin Klein. Rabbi Klein explained that since the mikvah in Long Beach is so important to the Rebbe, the Rebbe is sending \$5,000 by Air Mail Special Delivery (the quickest and most expensive mail delivery service at that time) to cover 10% of the mikvah's costs. This was a deviation from the Rebbe's practice of reimbursing new institutions 10% of their total costs upon completion of the building and took Rabbi Piekarski by great surprise. "We did not even have a piece of property upon which to build," he exclaims.

As Rabbi Piekarski was digesting the significance of this most unexpected phone call, the phone rang a second time. It was Rabbi Klein once again. The Rebbe had requested that Rabbi Klein relay his words to Mrs. Piekarski, as she would ensure that the mikvah come to be.

Rabbi Piekarski had always been intrigued by the fact that whenever he would encounter Rabbi Hodakov A"H while visiting New York, Rabbi Hodakov would consistently raise the subject of building a mikvah in Long Beach. With the Long Beach community at that time seemingly so far removed from Jewish observance, the notion of building a mikvah there had seemed almost absurd and Rabbi Piekarski had always put the thought on the back burner. Needless to say, the Rebbe's wishes were now very clear to him.

Though only three couples in Long Beach kept Taharas HaMishpocha at that time, since the Rebbe had expressed such great interest in the mikvah, the Piekarskis went to great lengths to make the mikvah beautiful, an unheard of phenomenon in mikvaos at that time. To their utter surprise, 140 women showed up for the mikvah's opening. In the 40 years since then, the mikvah has seen thousands of users, and, along with it, a tremendous revival of Yiddishkeit in the city. **C**

WRITTEN BY MRS. ELKY RAITPORT